

Legal Dictionary App

Shareable Legal Term Cards — Reference Specification



Project	Legal Dictionary — Word & Meaning App
Purpose	Let students, professionals, and the public look up legal terms and share them as branded image cards on WhatsApp Status and Instagram Stories
Audience	Frontend, Backend, and Database teams — Industry Readiness Program
API Style	REST, JSON over HTTPS
Version	v1
Base URL	https://api.legaldictionary.app/v1

1. Overview & Core Idea
2. General Conventions (Auth, Response Format, Errors, Pagination)
3. Data Models (Term, Category, Share Image)
4. Endpoints — Browsing & Search
5. Endpoints — Shareable Image Generation
6. Endpoints — Favorites (Signed-in Users)
7. Endpoints — Admin (Content Management)
8. Status Code Reference
9. End-to-End Example Flow

1. Overview & Core Idea

This app is a searchable dictionary of legal terms and maxims. Its defining feature is that every word's meaning can be rendered as a **shareable image card** — designed to be posted directly to WhatsApp Status or Instagram Stories. A student, professional, or curious learner should be able to search a term, view its meaning, and share it as an image in under three taps.

Why this matters for the contract: Because the image itself is a real, addressable resource (not just a UI screen), it needs its own endpoint, its own dimensions, and its own contract — just like any other piece of data. Treat the "Get Share Image" endpoint with the same seriousness as any data endpoint.

Core User Actions

- Browse legal terms by category (e.g. Legal Maxims, Contract Law, Criminal Law)
- Search for a specific term or phrase
- View a term's full meaning, example usage, and origin
- Generate and download/share a branded image card of that term
- (Signed-in users) Save terms to a personal favorites list
- (Admin) Add, edit, or remove terms from the dictionary

2. General Conventions

2.1 Authentication

Browsing, searching, and viewing terms is **public** — no login required, since the whole point is easy access. Saving favorites and admin actions require a bearer token.

ACCESS LEVEL	HOW	APPLIES TO
Public	No header required	Browsing, search, term detail, image generation
User	Authorization: Bearer <user_token>	Favorites
Admin	Authorization: Bearer <admin_token>	Create / update / delete terms

2.2 Standard Response Envelope

Every response — success or failure — follows the same shape, so the frontend can handle responses generically instead of writing custom logic for every endpoint.

SUCCESS RESPONSE

```
{
  "success": true,
  "data": { /* endpoint-specific payload */ },
  "error": null
}
```

ERROR RESPONSE

```
{
  "success": false,
  "data": null,
  "error": {
    "code": "TERM_NOT_FOUND",
    "message": "No legal term exists with this id."
  }
}
```

2.3 Pagination

Any endpoint that returns a list accepts `page` and `limit` query parameters and returns a `meta` block.

```
{
  "success": true,
  "data": [ /* array of items */ ],
  "meta": {
    "page": 1,
    "limit": 20,
    "totalItems": 184,
    "totalPages": 10
  },
  "error": null
}
```

2.4 Naming & Formatting Rules

- All fields use **camelCase** (e.g. `createdAt`, not `created_at`)
- All dates/times are **ISO 8601** strings, UTC (e.g. `2026-08-14T10:30:00Z`)

- All IDs are strings (UUID format), never raw integers
- URLs (images, etc.) are always full absolute URLs, never relative paths

3. Data Models

3.1 Term Object

FIELD	TYPE	DESCRIPTION
id	string	Unique identifier (UUID)
word	string	The legal term itself, e.g. "Habeas Corpus"
slug	string	URL-safe version, e.g. "habeas-corpus"
meaning	string	Plain-language definition
example	string null	Example sentence showing usage
origin	string null	Language of origin, e.g. "Latin"
categoryId	string	References a Category object
createdAt	string	ISO 8601 timestamp
updatedAt	string	ISO 8601 timestamp

3.2 Category Object

FIELD	TYPE	DESCRIPTION
id	string	Unique identifier
name	string	e.g. "Legal Maxims", "Contract Law"
description	string	Short description of the category
termCount	number	How many terms belong to this category

3.3 Share Image Object

FIELD	TYPE	DESCRIPTION
termId	string	Term this image represents
variant	string	"story" "square" "post"
format	string	"png" or "jpeg"
url	string	Direct CDN URL to the rendered image
width	number	Pixel width
height	number	Pixel height

4. Endpoints — Browsing & Search

GET /categories **PUBLIC**

Returns all available categories, used to build filter chips or a browse menu.

RESPONSE 200

```
{
  "success": true,
  "data": [
    { "id": "cat_maxims", "name": "Legal Maxims", "description": "Classical Latin legal principles", "termCount": 42 },
    { "id": "cat_contract", "name": "Contract Law", "description": "Terms related to agreements", "termCount": 67 }
  ],
  "error": null
}
```

[GET](#) /terms **PUBLIC**

List and search terms. Supports search text, category filter, and pagination.

QUERY PARAMETERS

PARAM	TYPE	REQUIRED	DESCRIPTION
q	string	No	Search text, matched against word and meaning
categoryId	string	No	Filter to one category
page	number	No	Default 1
limit	number	No	Default 20, max 50

EXAMPLE REQUEST

```
GET /terms?q=habeas&categoryId=cat_maxims&page=1&limit=20
```

RESPONSE 200

```
{
  "success": true,
  "data": [
    {
      "id": "term_0192",
      "word": "Habeas Corpus",
      "slug": "habeas-corpus",
      "meaning": "A legal action requiring a person under arrest to be brought before a judge.",
      "categoryId": "cat_maxims"
    }
  ],
  "meta": { "page": 1, "limit": 20, "totalItems": 1, "totalPages": 1 },
  "error": null
}
```

List responses return a **trimmed** version of the Term object (no `example`, `origin`, `timestamps`) to keep list payloads light. Full detail comes from the single-term endpoint below.

[GET](#) /terms/{id} **PUBLIC**

Full detail for one term, including example usage and origin.

RESPONSE 200

```
{
  "success": true,
  "data": {
    "id": "term_0192",
    "word": "Habeas Corpus",
    "slug": "habeas-corpus",
    "meaning": "A legal action requiring a person under arrest to be brought before a judge.",
    "example": "The lawyer filed a writ of habeas corpus to challenge the detention.",
    "origin": "Latin",
    "categoryId": "cat_maxims",
    "createdAt": "2026-01-10T09:00:00Z",
    "updatedAt": "2026-01-10T09:00:00Z"
  },
  "error": null
}
```

ERROR 404

```
{ "success": false, "data": null, "error": { "code": "TERM_NOT_FOUND", "message": "No legal term exists with this id." } }
```

[GET](#) /terms/random **PUBLIC**

Returns one random term. Powers a "Word of the Day" or shuffle feature on the home screen. Response shape is identical to `GET /terms/{id}`.

5. Endpoints — Shareable Image Generation

This is the feature that makes the app worth using. Every term can be rendered as a branded image card, sized correctly for either a story format (WhatsApp Status / Instagram Story) or a square format (Instagram feed post).

5.1 Image Variant Specification

Variant	Dimensions	Aspect Ratio	Best For
story	1080 × 1920 px	9:16	WhatsApp Status, Instagram / Facebook Stories
square	1080 × 1080 px	1:1	Instagram feed post, WhatsApp DM share
post	1080 × 1350 px	4:5	Instagram portrait feed post

What the image must contain: the word, its meaning (kept short — long meanings should be truncated with "... and the full text stays in-app), the category tag, and small app branding/watermark in a corner so shared images are recognizable as coming from this app. This content list should be treated as part of the contract — frontend/design should not silently add or remove elements from the card layout.

GET /terms/{id}/image **PUBLIC**

Returns the URL(s) of the ready-to-share image for a term. Images are pre-rendered and cached — this endpoint does not generate an image live on every call, it looks one up (or triggers generation once, the first time a term is requested).

QUERY PARAMETERS

PARAM	TYPE	REQUIRED	DESCRIPTION
variant	string	No	"story" "square" "post". If omitted, all three are returned.

RESPONSE 200

```
{
  "success": true,
  "data": {
    "termId": "term_0192",
    "images": [
      { "variant": "story", "format": "png", "url": "https://cdn.legaldictionary.app/cards/term_0192_story.png", "width": 1080, "height": 1920 },
      { "variant": "square", "format": "png", "url": "https://cdn.legaldictionary.app/cards/term_0192_square.png", "width": 1080, "height": 1080 }
    ]
  },
  "error": null
}
```

Frontend uses the platform's native share sheet (e.g. Web Share API / native share intent) with this image URL — the backend never talks to WhatsApp or Instagram directly. Sharing is a device-level action, not an API call.

POST /terms/{id}/share **PUBLIC**

Optional analytics call — frontend fires this right after the user's share action completes, purely to track which terms get shared most. Does not block or affect the share itself.

REQUEST BODY

```
{
  "variant": "story",
  "platform": "whatsapp" // "whatsapp" | "instagram" | "other"
}
```

RESPONSE 200

```
{ "success": true, "data": { "recorded": true }, "error": null }
```

6. Endpoints — Favorites (Signed-in Users)

POST /favorites **USER**

Save a term to the signed-in user's favorites list.

REQUEST BODY

```
{ "termId": "term_0192" }
```

RESPONSE 201

```
{ "success": true, "data": { "favoriteId": "fav_331", "termId": "term_0192", "savedAt": "2026-08-14T10:30:00Z" }, "error": null }
```

GET /favorites **USER**

List the signed-in user's saved terms. Returns trimmed Term objects, paginated.

DELETE /favorites/{favoriteId} **USER**

Remove a term from favorites.

RESPONSE 200

```
{ "success": true, "data": { "deleted": true }, "error": null }
```

7. Endpoints — Admin (Content Management)

POST /admin/terms **ADMIN**

Create a new legal term. Triggers image generation for all three variants automatically after creation.

REQUEST BODY

```
{
  "word": "Bona Fide",
  "meaning": "In good faith; genuine, without intent to deceive.",
  "example": "He made a bona fide offer to purchase the property.",
  "origin": "Latin",
  "categoryId": "cat_maxims"
}
```

RESPONSE 201

```
{ "success": true, "data": { "id": "term_0193", /* ...full Term object */ }, "error": null }
```

PUT /admin/terms/{id} **ADMIN**

Update an existing term. Re-triggers image generation so the share card reflects the edited text.

DELETE /admin/terms/{id} **ADMIN**

Remove a term and its generated images.

RESPONSE 200

```
{ "success": true, "data": { "deleted": true }, "error": null }
```

8. Status Code Reference

Code	Meaning	When It's Used
200	OK	Successful GET, PUT, or DELETE
201	Created	Successful POST that creates a new resource (term, favorite)
400	Bad Request	Missing/invalid fields, e.g. creating a term without a "word"
401	Unauthorized	Missing or invalid bearer token on a User/Admin endpoint
403	Forbidden	Valid user token used on an Admin-only endpoint
404	Not Found	Term, category, or favorite id doesn't exist
409	Conflict	Favoriting a term that's already in the user's favorites
500	Internal Server Error	Unexpected failure, including image generation failure

9. End-to-End Example Flow

How the endpoints above connect in a real user session — useful for frontend developers planning screen-to-screen navigation, and for backend developers checking their endpoints support the full journey.

- **Home screen loads** → GET /categories and GET /terms/random for the "Word of the Day" card
- **User searches "contract"** → GET /terms?q=contract
- **User taps a result** → GET /terms/{id} for full detail
- **User taps "Share"** → GET /terms/{id}/image?variant=story, then the device's native share sheet opens with that image
- **After share completes** → POST /terms/{id}/share (analytics, fire-and-forget)
- **User taps "Save"** (signed in) → POST /favorites